

says prices of flat-panel displays and memory will fall, leading to an overall drop in prices of entry-level notebooks. This will also mean that higher-end models will have more features at the same price. Says Grover: "The notebook market has exploded in more ways than one. In this fiscal, we have seen three-digit growth rates in terms of units sold and around 70 per cent in terms of revenue. The Indian executive has realised that being productive at all times is important, and mobility is one thing that is making it possible. A laptop is a business necessity today."

He also adds: "We are trying to be as affordable as possible. Besides since India will be a signatory to the WTO agreement, it is possible that Customs Duty may be relaxed further this year on IT products. I guess the market will mainly focus on weight of the unit, wide-screen technology, connectivity to various devices, and entertainment options."

The Wireless Paradigm

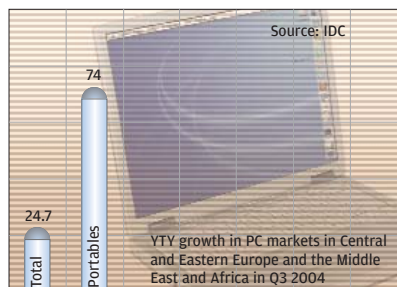
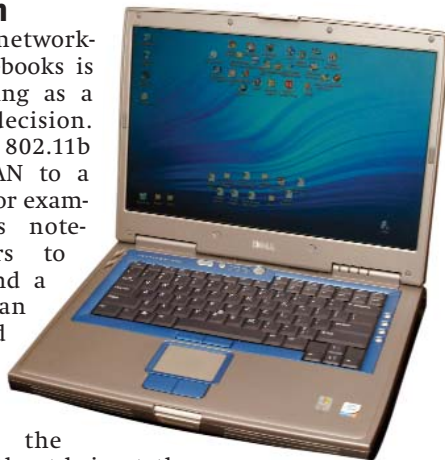
Wireless networking in notebooks is fast emerging as a buying decision. Adding 802.11b wireless LAN to a notebook, for example, allows notebook users to move around a home or an office and maintain a

connection to the Internet without being tethered to a cable. Many notebook makers such as IBM and Dell are pre-installing antennas that allow people to take advantage of 802.11b by purchasing an add-in radio card for their notebook. Apple Computer was one of the first to integrate 802.11b support into its portables.

Says R Raghu, senior product manager, Acer India: "We plan to bring in the SignalUp technology to laptops this year to facilitate the wireless LAN environment. We will also focus on Centrino and Mobile Celeron product lines in 2005." He adds that notebooks have become lighter and thinner recently, and have reached the power of desktops in all respects.

Yeh Dil Maange More

Users say they expect more and more features this year in their laptops. Says software consultant Deepak Shah, who currently uses an IBM Pensar 380, but will be investing in a new notebook this year: "When I purchased the IBM, my needs were limited. But today I work in Visual Basic, Oracle, SQL, etc. Naturally, I require a high-end system. I



Buying Tips

- ✓ Centrino recommended
- ✓ In Centrino, rather in Pentium M processor, look for 2 MB cache instead of 1 MB
- ✓ In WLAN, 802.11g has higher data transfer rate (55 Mbps) when compared with 802.11b (11 Mbps)
- ✓ Insist on a Combo Drive
- ✓ Ensure the laptop is lightweight. Bulky laptops can lead to health issues for travelling executives
- ✓ Look for the optimal number of USB ports
- ✓ Insist on at least a 40 GB hard drive
- ✓ Widescreen or Wide Aspect Ratio based Laptops when you want better screen quality
- ✓ Ensure your brand is reputable, and has an internationally-known service network

would prefer to buy notebooks that have world-wide warranty." Shah does not mind paying up to Rs 1.5 lakh for his notebook, but wants an auto backup facility, wireless LAN, considerable battery life and a lightweight unit.

Zenith's Saraf says that her company will have more interactive features in its laptops in 2005. "Zenith's new VU range of laptops has an in-built camera and more features. Newer technologies such as the Intel's Centrino Mobile will save laptops from price wars, though."

Anshuman Purohit, planning manager, Madison India, owns an Acer Travelmate. "I use it to surf the Net and listen to music. But I would like to have an IBM machine that is Bluetooth-enabled, is lightweight, and has a data recovery system." On the other hand, graphic designer Kausarali Bastawala, is looking specifically to buying a high-end Sony notebook, with a configuration that will appeal to graphic designers. "It should have enormous RAM, a high-end graphics card, good colour resolution, and high processing speed." For this, he does not mind paying up to Rs 1.5 lakh.

Mariam Samuel, meanwhile, uses his laptop to check email wherever he is; to keep a backup of his work, and to run high-end applications such as Autocad and Corel Draw. But he says he will buy a new machine only towards the end of the year. But his wishlist includes a small built-in printer, "so I can give clients printouts immediately".

The World Over

IDC figures indicate that worldwide laptop sales grew 11.6 per cent in 2002, compared to 2.7 per cent growth in PC sales with HP and Dell leading the pack with market shares of 17 and 16 per cent respectively. But importantly, more than 90 per cent of all new laptops would be Wi-Fi ready by end-2005, up from 35 per cent by end-2003.

It does not really matter, though, how much the market swings this year with respect to notebooks. Just as the desktop has become a part of life, notebooks are fast becoming another way of life for the executive as well as the home user. ■

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